was formulated in 2014, known as National Action Plan (NAP), which was misconstrued as the strategy.

There were several reasons for the absence of a CT strategy. There was a lack of unity of approach among the political leaders on the ways to tackle the terrorists. The divided mindset of the leadership and sympathy for Islamic hardline groups at a societal level not only gave the militants enough space to sustain themselves and flourish but also had been a big hurdle in reaching a consensus to tackle them.

Terrorism in Pakistan was a complex issue as it emanated from the insurgency in FATA. The policymakers failed to differentiate between the two and to understand that countering insurgency is far different from countering terrorism.

From the very beginning, the army had been in charge of the realm of counter-terrorism. This trend had set in from the era of General Musharraf and continued after it too. Civilian leadership did not wrest control of national security affairs and felt contented with the army handling the situation.

The absence of political resolve and interest reflected in the civil institutions established for fighting against terrorism. National Counter Terrorism Authority (NACTA) was established to devise a counter-terrorism strategy for Pakistan in 2008. It failed to start due to turf war between the Ministry of Interior and the Prime Minister's office. It would not be an overstatement that it remained dormant ever since its formation. It was a litmus test of political non-seriousness to devise a counter-terrorism strategy (Sehgal, 2010). Until 2018, NACTA was observed to be performing in a slipshod manner.

'The most important weapon in any campaign against terrorism is intelligence' (Koch, 2007). However, ISI, Intelligence Bureau (IB), Federal Investigation Agency (FIA), Special Branches of Police and others lacked sustained coordination to counter terrorism. They looked towards the political leadership for seriousness of purpose, which was not evident, and they probably wanted to guard their turfs as well. CT strategy did not suit them, which could compel them to act in unison.

Despite the lack of a National Counter-Terrorism strategy, Pakistan had been somehow tackling terrorism by any means. Main reliance was on target hardening of sensitive buildings and areas. The government and all others tried to save themselves by beefing up security of vulnerable places and buildings. Whether it was a hotel or a police office,